

■ By Saurabh Shukla

A Red Maoist regime in Kathmandu may not be the best pain reliever for the trouble-ridden Himalayan country, but it is a historic opportunity to prove the critics wrong as guerrilla fatigues make way for the trappings of government.

Nepal is still in a state of flux as the new rulers grapple with coalition hurdles over who will head the government and who will be the first President of the new republic. As the parties squabble for a bigger pie, the session of the Constituent Assembly has again been postponed. The Maoists, who continue to be on the US government's visa watch list and control only one-third of the 600-member Assembly seats, are in the driver's seat. Even as Communist Party of Nepal (Maoist) chief Prachanda looks set to become prime minister, the Nepali Congress wants the President's chair for the current prime minister G.P. Koirala. There is tough competition from the other Left party, the Unified Marxist-Leninist, whose leader Madhav Kumar Nepal has thrown his hat in the ring.

India has a strategic stake in Nepal, with which it shares a 1,900-km open border. The current political situation does not augur well for its vital security and economic interests. For now, South Block is busy trying to assuage the sentiments of the Maoists, who were upset when India's National Security Adviser M.K. Narayanan said that a Nepali Congress regime would be best for India. While the top Maoist leadership has toned down its rhetoric, New Delhi, which has traditionally supported the Nepali



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RED BRIGADE:
Prachanda, the leader
of the Communist Party
of Nepal (Maoist)

tears for King Gyanendra and his family, who will now lead the life of commoners. His throne was formally abolished last month and on June 11, he packed all his belongings and bid adieu to Narayanhiti Palace—which will be turned into a national museum—from where his ancestors, the Shah Dynasty, ruled the Himalayan Kingdom for 240 years. Though the 60-year-old has said that he has no intention of leaving the country and will “help establish peace”, in the days to come, his assets, running into several million dollars, are expected to come under the governmental scanner.

For the Maoists, a key challenge will be to ensure that the Young Communist League, their youth outfit, which has been accused of extortion, is brought under control. The security situation in the country is still far from normal. A recent United Nations report paints a grim picture citing the rampant bombings and kidnappings in the country. The new rulers in Kathmandu will also have to ensure that the ethnic group of Madhesi, who constitute around 33 per cent of the total population, get their due and that their demand for a federal structure is addressed.

However, India is hoping that the new Government will address its security concerns. It has even sensitised the Maoist leadership about *madrasas* mushrooming on the border and Prachanda has assured New Delhi that he will do his best to change Nepal's image as the hotbed of terror. The open Indo-Nepal border

BIRTH PANGS

As the Himalayan country goes the republic way, India hopes that the change in the political landscape will augur well for a stable democracy

Congress, has realised that it cannot afford to antagonise the party in power. India wants a stable government in the neighbourhood and hopes that the parties will reconcile their differences and come together to bring much-needed change in the political landscape of the country.

Even as the parties work towards a solution, few in Kathmandu will shed